

THE TWO SONS OF JOSEPH

TEXT: Genesis 41:50-52 (NKJV) *“And to Joseph were born two sons before the years of famine came, whom Asenath, the daughter of Poti-Pherah priest of On, bore to him. ⁵¹Joseph called the name of the firstborn Manasseh: “For God has made me forget all my toil and all my father’s house.” ⁵²And the name of the second he called Ephraim: “For God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”*

INTRO: I love the story of the life of Joseph because it is a perfect example of a life marked and marred by adversity, yet, despite the problematic path, the grace of God is shown through a life of integrity. Though Joseph was born with a silver spoon in his mouth, the real Joseph is placed on display when crisis after crisis attempts to keep him from all God intended him to be.

Look at a snapshot of Joseph’s life:

- Joseph was the son of Jacob and Rachel...
- At the age of seventeen he is tending the flock of Jacob, his Father...
- Joseph was the favorite child of his father because he was the child of his old age...
- Because of parental partiality, he was hated by his brothers... (Coat of Many Colors)
- He began to dream dreams of exaltation, such as the dream of binding sheaves and the sheaves of his brothers bowing down to him; the sun, the moon, and eleven stars making obeisance to him...
- Because of his dreams, his brother’s dislike for him turned to hatred...
- Joseph’s brothers conspire to kill him, but Reuben says, *“Let’s put him in a pit and leave him there,”* thinking he would come later and deliver Joseph unto his father...
- His brothers took his Coat of many Colors and dipped it in blood, deliver it unto Jacob, his father, and allowed him to believe a wild beast killed Joseph... (His brothers actually sold him to the Midianites)
- The Midianite Merchantmen sold him to the Ishmeelites for 20 pieces of silver...
- The Ishmeelites sold Joseph to Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh...
- Potiphar recognizes the Lord is with Joseph, because everything Joseph touches becomes a success...

- Potiphar makes Joseph the Business Manager of his entire fortune...
- God prospers Joseph as the business manager of Potiphar, as a result, his master realizes some very hefty profits...
- The wife of Potiphar tries unsuccessfully to seduce Joseph... Notice the words of Joseph when faced with such a tantalizing temptation, ***“I refuse to commit this sin against my God.”***
- When the wife of Potiphar sees that Joseph is a young man of integrity and will not commit adultery with her, she lies to Potiphar and Joseph is put in prison...
- Joseph is made overseer of all the prisoners...
- While Joseph is in prison, Pharaoh’s butler and baker become inmates...
- The butler and baker both dream dreams and Joseph interprets them upon the condition that when the butler is restored, he will tell the king of Joseph’s injustice...
- Just as Joseph predicts, the butler is restored to the King’s favor and the baker is hanged...
- Two years pass before the butler makes good on his promise to Joseph...
- Pharaoh dreams a dream that no one could interpret. This dream was of seven fat cattle coming up out of the river and then seven poor cattle coming up out of the river. The seven poor cattle ate up the seven fat cattle. Then he dreamed again and seven fat ears of corn sprang up on one stalk and seven thin ears of corn on another stalk blasted by the east wind. The seven thin ears ate up the seven fat ears. Pharaoh had a nightmare...
- Pharaoh’s butler says, ***“I know someone who can interpret this dream.”*** The butler makes good on his promise to Joseph...
- Joseph interprets Pharaohs dream of seven years of plenty and seven years of famine...
- Joseph is made second-in-command in Egypt...

Remember, about fourteen years have transpired since Joseph was sold into Egypt.

This is where we pick up our scriptures today.

Notice: Joseph had two sons. Look at what he named them.

I. THE FIRSTBORN HE NAMED MANASSEH!

In Bible days, people named their children for something of significance in their life. When Joseph's first child was born he named him Manasseh. Manasseh means *"causing to forget or forgetfulness."* Notice vs. 51 ***"And Joseph called the name of the firstborn Manasseh: For God, said he hath made me forget all my toil, and all my father's house."***

What is Joseph saying here?

- Is he saying that God has removed his mother, father and eleven brothers from his memory? No!
- Is he saying that God has erased the maltreatment by his siblings from his memory? No!
- Is he saying that God has stricken the rejection by his brothers from his memory? No!

He is simply saying that God has taken the pain out of a past experience for Him. If anyone has ever had a reason to be bitter and have a critical attitude, surely Joseph did.

How could a guy who had been through what Joseph had endured ever be able to get past the pain? The path to peace in Joseph's life is really pretty simple. When his first son was born, he named him Manasseh meaning, ***"The Lord hath made me to forget."*** While Joseph could not forget his father, mother and eleven brothers, what he could do was to forgive them, and that he did!

Have you ever been wronged? Been rejected? Treated badly? Been double crossed? Cheated out of something? These things can bring with them a boat load of pain. How we react to these things will define who we are! If we forgive we can move on with our life and become who God intended us to be, if we withhold forgiveness, we immediately become stunted in our growth pattern and slowly but surely become critical if not downright bitter!

Many have critical spirits, who call themselves Christians. Why are they critical? Because they have never come to a place of letting God take the pain out of a past experience. Past experiences are why some people don't serve God today. If we allow past experiences to stand between us and serving God, we will lose out with God and our lives will be less than they were intended to be.

Most people fail to forgive, hoping to inflict pain on the un-forgiven individual when in reality the person who is withholding forgiveness places themselves in a prison for a life term or until forgiveness can be dispensed.

I don't know what you have been going through but if Joseph could endure all this, and forget the past, surely you and I can forget the past and serve God victoriously!

Keys to victory:

- Allow God to take the pain out of a past experience... Paul, who had everything happen to him except his life being taken from him says in Philippians 3:13-14 (NKJV) ***“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”*** How in the world is it possible to allow God to take the pain out of a past experience for us? First of all we must forgive! While teaching His disciples how to pray Jesus makes this statement, Matthew 6:12 (NKJV) ***“And forgive us our debts, As we forgive our debtors.”*** If that is not enough, following “The Lord’s Prayer” He says to His disciples, almost as an afterthought, Matthew 6:14-15 (NKJV) ***“For if you forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you. ¹⁵“But if you do not forgive men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.”*** How is this kind of forgiveness possible? The Bible tells us that God has ***“Taken our sins and cast them as far as the East is from the West never to be remembered against us again.”*** Think of what Christ did for us upon the cross of Calvary. Now think of all the times we have sinned against Him. As soon as we asked to be forgiven, He forgave us and forgot it, pure and simple! If He has done all of this for us, then we cannot withhold forgiveness from our brethren. (Ex. Parable of man who owed his master much, the debt was forgiven, and then he turned around and did not forgive a little debt owed to him.) Many people are just that way. Not only must we forgive, but if we think your brother or sister has a problem with us, we are responsible to go to that person and straighten things out. Matthew 5:23-24 (NKJV) ***“Therefore if you bring your gift to the altar, and there***

remember that your brother has something against you,

²⁴*“leave your gift there before the altar, and go your way.*

First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift.”

A lack of forgiveness is the very reason many Christians never mature, they have never learned to forgive. A good exercise for forgiveness is to write a letter of forgiveness... Make a phone call of forgiveness...

- Live in the present and the future and minimize the failures of the past... Philippians 3:13-14 (NKJV) ***“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”*** Un-forgiveness requires a lot of energy and attention. If we channel this energy and attention toward what is happening today and tomorrow we will not have what it takes to keep holding to the past!
- Do good deeds to those who have wronged us... Matthew 5:43-45 (NKJV) ***“You have heard that it was said, ‘You shall love your neighbor and hate your enemy.’ ⁴⁴“But I say to you, love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who spitefully use you and persecute you, ⁴⁵“that you may be sons of your Father in heaven; for He makes His sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust.”*** That’s a tall order, so how do we do this? Paul told the Phillipian Christians, Philippians 4:8 (NKJV) ***“Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things.”*** When we begin to allow God’s Word to do its work in us we do not have to do God’s work for Him, He will manifest His miracles through us! We must allow our minds to be ridded of past failures, defeats, and wrongs, by dwelling on good things, forgetting the past, and dwelling on the future!

We see a perfect example of these things being pressed into service in the life of Joseph. Joseph’s 10 brothers came to buy corn in Egypt at the command of their father Jacob. Joseph had the authority and the motive to kill every one of them but notice what he did. He gives them their corn, and

puts their money back in their sacks. He keeps Simeon so that they will bring Benjamin back with them.

As a last resort, Jacob consents to let Benjamin come with them. Joseph makes a feast for them, gives them corn and supplies, and once again puts their money back in their sacks, only this time he puts his silver cup in Benjamin's sack and lets them go. When they are gone, he sends his servants after them and his servants find the cup in Benjamin's sack. Joseph's brothers plead with him, not knowing with whom they were pleading then he reveals who he is. His brothers are afraid for their lives.

Listen to the words of Joseph when his brothers realize who they are dealing with. Genesis 45:4-8 (NKJV) ***"And Joseph said to his brothers, 'Please come near to me.' So they came near. Then he said: 'I am Joseph your brother, whom you sold into Egypt. ⁵'But now, do not therefore be grieved or angry with yourselves because you sold me here; for God sent me before you to preserve life. ⁶'For these two years the famine has been in the land, and there are still five years in which there will be neither plowing nor harvesting. ⁷'And God sent me before you to preserve a posterity for you in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance. ⁸'So now it was not you who sent me here, but God; and He has made me a father to Pharaoh, and lord of all his house, and a ruler throughout all the land of Egypt.'***

The reason Joseph could deal with his brothers so gently when they come to buy corn in Egypt is because he forgave them long before they arrived! Why? Because ***"Manasseh, the Lord hath made me to forget!"*** He named his son Manasseh so that each time he spoke his son's name, he was reminded to keep forgiving his brothers. As he forgave his brothers he was releasing his own family from the shackles of the curse of un-forgiveness!

This very same thing can happen to you! I don't know about you, but I believe there were probably days when the past would begin to bother him and all he had to do was to look at Manasseh and that was enough to cause him to forget the past.

I. THE SECOND SON HE NAMED EPHRAIM!

A. What does the name Ephraim mean? It simply means, “Double fruit.”

Genesis 41:52 says, “And the name of the second called he Ephraim; for God hath caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”

There are 2 things here for us to note. 1) God hath caused me to be fruitful. 2) God hath caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.

1) God caused Joseph to be fruitful. Why? Because he was a man of integrity, and he feared the Lord.

God hath caused me to be fruitful in the land of my afflictions.

2) We are living in a time when I’m convinced that God wants to pour out his spirit upon His churches and His people as never before.

There is a story found in II Kings 2 about two men named Elijah and Elisha.

Elijah was the elder prophet of God.

Elisha was his assistant. Elijah was going to be taken away and Elisha followed him from Gilgal to Bethel, which means “the House of God.”

They went from Bethel to Jericho, which means “to accept, to make of quick understanding.” Which has to do with our position and our responsibility?

They went from Jericho to Jordan, which means “a place of coming down.” Which has to do with our advancing as a church against satan’s strongholds?

They crossed Jordan. Elijah asks Elisha, “What do you want.” He says, “A DOUBLE PORTION OF WHAT YOU HAVE.”

Elijah said, ”You’ve asked a hard thing, but if you see me when I’m taken away then you will have it.”

Elisha saw Elijah go. Elijah’s mantle fell back to the ground. **Sons of the prophets!**

Elisha took it, wrapped it together, and said, “WHERE IS THE LORD GOD OF ELIJAH.” He smote the waters and they parted.

SAMSON – “Judge”

My prayer is - God give us some people who will dare to get the fullness of God in their lives. (Our youngsters need to see a manifestation of God’s power today. David said, “God, forsake me not until I have shown thy strength to this generation and thy power to everyone that is to come.)

- 3) Even though we are living in a time when the spirit is being poured out we are also pilgrims and strangers here. We are living in the land of affliction so to speak.

We can either take the example of Elisha or the example of Samson in the Book of Judges.

He laid his head in the lap of Delilah and his power was lost.

Brother, many times it has happened; the church has laid its head in the lap of the world and lost its power.
Joel 2:17-29 (Sis. Eubanks)

- B. Joseph lived in the land of affliction but he walked uprightly before God.

1) Because he walked uprightly before God, God blessed him.

How did God bless him? Financially, family-wise (Ephraim – double fruit – I believe that every time he looked at that boy, he praised God for his goodness.) He blessed him spiritually and helped him be able to forgive.

For even in the land of affliction he had a revelation from God.

Genesis 50:24-25 “And Joseph said unto his brethren, I die: and God will surely visit you and bring you out of this land unto the land which he swore to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob. 25) And Joseph took an oath of the children of Israel, saying, God will surely visit you, and ye shall carry up my bones from hence.”

Brother, my prayer is that God will once again reveal Jesus Christ to us by the Holy Ghost even in the Land of Affliction.

THE END!